

Worth Their Weight. • Connecting Vets to What's Theirs

VSO Prep Packet

Everything you need to walk into your first meeting with a Veterans Service Organization ready.

Who this is for. Any veteran getting ready to file for benefits. You do not need a diagnosis, paperwork already in hand, or a plan. You just need to show up ready, and this packet gets you there.

What a VSO is. A Veterans Service Organization has representatives who are accredited by the VA to help you file your claim and represent you through it. They work for you, not the VA, and an accredited VSO never charges you. They are the ones who advise on and file the claim. That part is theirs, not ours.

How to use this packet. Work through the three parts before your meeting. Check the boxes, gather the one record that matters most, and know what to expect when you sit down. The more you bring, the more the VSO can do in the first sitting.

PART 1

Things You Might Be Carrying

What this is. A way to notice what you have been living with. A lot of veterans carry something for years without ever connecting it to their service. Read down the list and check anything that sounds like you.

What this is not. It is not a claim form, and it is not a list of what to file for. Checking a box does not mean you qualify for anything. It means it is worth raising with your VSO.

What to do with it. Bring your checked list to the meeting. It gives the VSO the fuller picture of what you have been carrying, so nothing gets left out. They decide what gets filed. We do not advise on that part.

01 Back, Joints & Body

- ☐ Low back or neck pain that never fully went away
- ☐ Knees, hips, ankles, or shoulders that ache or give out
- ☐ Stiffness or reduced range of motion in a joint
- ☐ Foot pain, plantar fasciitis, or old ankle sprains
- ☐ Arthritis in a joint you injured in service
- ☐ Muscle weakness or loss of strength from an old injury
- ☐ An old injury that flares up with weather or activity

02 Hearing & Ears

- ☐ Ringing or buzzing in the ears (tinnitus)
- ☐ Trouble hearing in noise or asking people to repeat
- ☐ Ear pain or recurring infections
- ☐ Dizziness, vertigo, or balance problems

03 Eyes & Vision

- ☐ Vision loss or worsening eyesight since service
- ☐ Chronic dry eye or light sensitivity
- ☐ An eye injury or exposure you never had looked at

04 Mental Health

- ☐ Reliving things that happened, or working hard to avoid them
- ☐ Feeling on guard, jumpy, or uneasy in crowds
- ☐ Depression, low mood, or loss of interest
- ☐ Anxiety, panic, or a racing mind
- ☐ Anger or irritability that costs you at home or work
- ☐ Effects of military sexual trauma (MST)
- ☐ Drinking or using more than you want to

05 Sleep

- ☐ Trouble falling or staying asleep
- ☐ Nightmares or waking up on edge
- ☐ Snoring, gasping, or being told you stop breathing (sleep apnea)
- ☐ Exhausted no matter how long you were in bed

06 Head & Nerves

- ☐ A head injury, blast, or concussion in service (TBI)
- ☐ Headaches or migraines
- ☐ Memory, focus, or word-finding trouble
- ☐ Numbness, tingling, or nerve pain in hands or feet
- ☐ Shooting pain down a leg or arm (sciatica, pinched nerve)
- ☐ Seizures or blackouts
- ☐ Tremors or shaking

07 Breathing

- ☐ Asthma, wheezing, or shortness of breath
- ☐ Chronic cough or bronchitis
- ☐ Sinus trouble or a chronically stuffy nose (rhinitis)

08 Heart & Circulation

- ☐ High blood pressure
- ☐ Heart disease or chest pain
- ☐ An irregular or racing heartbeat
- ☐ Varicose veins, poor circulation, or blood clots

09 Stomach & Digestion

- ☐ Acid reflux or heartburn (GERD)
- ☐ Irritable bowel, chronic diarrhea, or constipation (IBS)
- ☐ Ulcers or ongoing stomach pain
- ☐ Liver, gallbladder, or pancreas trouble
- ☐ A hernia

10 Skin & Scars

- ☐ Chronic rashes, eczema, or breakouts
- ☐ Scars from injuries or surgery
- ☐ Skin changes from sun or chemical exposure

11 Hormones & Metabolism

- ☐ Diabetes or blood sugar problems
- ☐ Thyroid trouble
- ☐ Unexplained weight or energy changes

12 Urinary & Reproductive

- ☐ Bladder or kidney problems
- ☐ Sexual dysfunction or reproductive issues
- ☐ Women's health conditions tied to service
- ☐ Conditions that showed up after a service injury or medication

13 Dental, Mouth & Jaw

- ☐ Jaw pain, clicking, or trouble opening (TMJ)
- ☐ Teeth lost or damaged from a service injury
- ☐ Chronic mouth or gum problems from service

14 Blood, Immune & Chronic Illness

- ☐ Anemia or a blood disorder
- ☐ An autoimmune condition
- ☐ Constant fatigue or widespread body pain (chronic fatigue, fibromyalgia)
- ☐ Lasting effects of an infection (hepatitis, and others)

15 Cancer

- ☐ Any cancer, active or in remission
- ☐ A cancer you believe is tied to a service exposure
- ☐ Lasting effects of cancer treatment

Were you around any of these?

Exposures during service can be tied to conditions that show up years later. If any of these are part of your story, say so at the meeting. You do not have to know the connection. That is what the VSO is for.

- ☐ Burn pits, smoke, or airborne hazards (Iraq, Afghanistan, and others)
- ☐ Agent Orange or other herbicides (Vietnam era and beyond)
- ☐ Contaminated water at Camp Lejeune
- ☐ Radiation or nuclear materials
- ☐ Gulf War service and unexplained chronic symptoms
- ☐ Asbestos, solvents, fuels, or industrial chemicals

Curious about the official source? The VA's full rating schedule lives in 38 CFR Part 4 at [ecfr.gov](https://www.ecfr.gov). It is written for VA raters, not for self-assessment, so use this checklist to prepare and let your VSO handle the rest.

PART 2

Finding Your DD-214

Why this one matters. Your DD-214 is the single document your VSO needs most. It is the key that unlocks benefits, health care, home loans, and burial honors. If yours is lost, damaged, or never made it into your hands, it can be replaced, and every official channel below is free.

Ask for the Member Copy 4. That is the long form. It shows your character of discharge, which the short form leaves off. Benefits offices want the long form. Skip any website that charges a fee to pull your records.

The three ways to get it, fastest first

1 milConnect (online, often same day)

BEST IF YOU SEPARATED RECENTLY AND YOUR RECORDS ARE DIGITAL

If you have a DS Logon, this is the quickest route and you may be able to download the file right away.

1. Go to milconnect.dmdc.osd.mil and sign in with your DS Logon
2. Open **Correspondence/Documentation**, then choose **Defense Personnel Records Information (DPRIS)**
3. Select the **Personnel File** tab, then **Request My Personnel File**
4. Check the box for your DD-214, then create and send the request

2 eVetRecs at the National Archives (mailed to you)

BEST FOR MOST VETERANS WHOSE RECORDS ARE NOT IN MILCONNECT

This reaches the National Personnel Records Center (NPRC) in St. Louis, where most DD-214s are stored. Routine requests in 2026 run around ten business days.

1. Go to vetrecs.archives.gov and start a new request
2. Enter your service details and select **DD-214, Member Copy 4**
3. Print the signature page it creates, sign it, and mail or fax it back as directed
4. NPRC mails your records to the address you gave

3 Standard Form 180 (paper, by mail or fax)

BEST FOR NEXT OF KIN, VSO OR ATTORNEY REQUESTS, AND OLDER RECORDS

Use the SF-180 when the request is on behalf of a deceased veteran, when a VSO or attorney is requesting with your signed authorization, or when you need older or non-standard records. Download it at archives.gov/veterans. Page 3 tells you the correct mailing address or fax number for your branch and separation date. Allow two to six weeks.

Need it fast? Ask for emergency processing.

If you have a documented deadline, an upcoming medical procedure, a funeral, or you are without stable housing, NPRC can expedite. Mark the request **EMERGENCY**.

Emergency fax to NPRC: **314-801-0764** · Customer service: **314-801-0800**

For burial at a VA National Cemetery, call the National Cemetery Scheduling Office: **800-535-1117**

Special situations

You may already have a free copy nearby

Many veterans filed their DD-214 with their county recorder or clerk when they got out. Call the county where you separated or settled and ask if a copy is on record. Your state department of veterans affairs can also help pull one.

Records lost in the 1973 fire

A 1973 fire at NPRC destroyed millions of files. Army records for people discharged between Nov 1912 and Jan 1960, and many Air Force records (names Hubbard through Z, Sep 1947 to Jan 1964), were affected. If yours was among them, NPRC can often rebuild proof of service from other records. Ask them to reconstruct.

The veteran has passed away

Surviving spouses, children, and parents can request records using the SF-180 with proof of death and proof of relationship. This is the standard path for next of kin.

Something on it is wrong

Errors are corrected with a DD-215, which attaches to your DD-214 rather than replacing it. An accredited VSO can walk you through it.

PART 3

Your First Meeting

The meeting is a conversation, not a test. Your VSO representative is on your side. They will ask about your service and your health, review what you bring, help identify what you may be eligible to claim, and prepare and file the paperwork for you. Be honest and be thorough. The things you play down are often the things that matter.

It is free, start to finish. An accredited VSO does not charge you to file or to represent you. If anyone asks for a fee to file your claim, that is your sign to walk away.

What to bring

- ☐ Your DD-214, Member Copy 4 (Part 2 shows you how to get it)
- ☐ Your completed checklist from Part 1
- ☐ Any medical records you have, from the VA or from civilian doctors
- ☐ A current list of your medications
- ☐ A photo ID
- ☐ Marriage and dependent information, if it applies to you
- ☐ Any prior VA letters or claim numbers, if you have them

What to expect

You do the talking, they do the paperwork. Your job is to tell your story. Theirs is to turn it into a claim.

They may enroll you in VA health care. That can happen alongside a claim, and it opens the door to treatment.

Filing is the start, not the finish. A claim takes time to work through the VA. Your VSO stays your representative the whole way.

You can bring someone. A spouse, a friend, or a fellow veteran. You do not have to do this alone.

Good questions to ask

- “ Am I enrolled in VA health care, and if not, can you help me enroll?
- “ Based on what I have told you, what might I be eligible for?
- “ How long does this usually take, and what happens after we file?
- “ Will you represent me through the entire claim?
- “ Is there anything I should gather before the next step?

PART 4

After You File

The claim is in. Now it takes time. Your claim moves through the VA at its own pace, and the wait is normal. Here is how to keep tabs on it and where to turn while you wait.

Check your claim status

Online. Sign in at va.gov/claim-or-appeal-status with Login.gov or ID.me. The VA: Health and Benefits app shows the same thing and can notify you when your status changes.

By phone. Call the VA benefits hotline at **800-827-1000**. Hours are Monday through Friday, 8:00 a.m. to 9:00 p.m. ET. TTY: 711. Have your Social Security or VA file number ready.

Through your VSO. Your representative can see details in the VA system that your own view does not show. If something looks stuck, ask them to check.

What to expect while you wait

You may be called in for a C&P exam. That is a Compensation and Pension exam. Go to it. If you cannot make the date, call 800-827-1000 to reschedule right away. A missed exam is one of the most common reasons a claim stalls.

Keep your contact info current on va.gov. That is how the VA reaches you about an exam or a request, and a missed notice costs time.

Keep getting care. Ongoing treatment documents your condition and strengthens your record.

Watch for the decision letter. The VA mails it when the claim is done, and you can also read it on va.gov.

If you disagree with the decision

A decision is not the end of the road. You generally have one year from the date on the letter to ask the VA to look again, and there is more than one way to do it. This is exactly where your VSO earns their keep. Bring them the letter and let them handle the next move. We do not advise on that part, but we help you get back in touch with the people who do.

Numbers worth keeping

VA benefits hotline, claim status: 800-827-1000 · TTY 711 · Mon–Fri, 8am–9pm ET

MyVA411, any VA question, 24/7: 800-698-2411

Vet Center, free counseling, any discharge, 24/7: 877-927-8387

Veterans Crisis Line: dial 988, then press 1 · or text 838255

Not sure where to start? Start with us.

If any of this feels like a lot, that is exactly what we are here for. We help you get ready, we connect you to an accredited VSO, and we stay with you after. You never do this alone, and it never costs you anything.

833-WTW-VETS (833) 989-8387



SCAN TO LEARN MORE

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